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Senators call for investigation into release, redaction of Epstein files

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KEY POINTS

A bipartisan group of Senators on Wednesday called on the Government Accountability Office to probe the Department of Justice's handling of files related to Jeffrey Epstein.

Lawmakers have on multiple occasions called for investigations into the DOJ's handling of the Epstein files.

The GAO is an independent, non-partisan congressional watchdog.



Newly-released documents from disgraced late financier and sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, including a sheaf of entirely redacted pages, are seen in handouts released by the Justice Department and printed and arranged for a photograph by Reuters in Washington, Dec. 19, 2025.

Jonathan Ernst | Reuters

A bipartisan group of [senators](#) on Wednesday called on the [Government Accountability Office](#) to investigate the [Department of Justice](#)'s release and redactions of documents related to disgraced sex offender [Jeffrey Epstein](#).

The letter, signed by Sens. [Dick Durbin](#), D-Ill., [Ben Ray Lujan](#), D-N.M., [Jeff Merkley](#), D-Ore., [Lisa Murkowski](#), R-Alaska, alleges the DOJ did not comply with a law that aimed to compel the release of the Epstein files while protecting victims.

“Contrary to Congress’s explicit directive to protect victims, these records included email addresses and nude photos in which the names and faces of publicly-identified and non-public victims could be identified,” the lawmakers wrote. “But when it came to information identifying powerful business and political figures who are alleged coconspirators or material witnesses, DOJ appears to have heavily redacted those records.”



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The GAO is an independent, non-partisan legislative branch agency with authority to audit and investigate the federal government.

The DOJ has been repeatedly criticized for withholding parts of the Epstein files from the public in violation of the [Epstein Files Transparency Act](#), which President [Donald Trump](#) signed in November after months of opposition. That law mandated the full release of documents by Dec. 19.

While the [DOJ has released](#) millions of documents to date, it blew past the December deadline and many more Epstein files entries have not yet been made public, prompting outcry from both Republican and Democratic members of Congress.

Lawmakers in both the House and Senate have called for the [DOJ's Inspector General](#) to investigate the department's handling of the Epstein files. The House Oversight Committee last week [voted to subpoena](#) Attorney General [Pam Bondi](#) as part of its probe into Epstein, who died in 2019.

The letter asks Acting Comptroller General Orice Williams Brown to review the "protocols and practices" the DOJ used for the review, redaction and release of the Epstein files and to report back to Congress. It specifically asks the GAO to investigate whether the release of the "files has served to cover up child sexual abuse."



failure to redact the victims' information and re-victimize those individuals while violating the Epstein Files Transparency Act in its redactions of information related to their alleged abusers.”

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